Unit 2. How to hear God's voice today (Tools)

Overview

This unit explores the topic of how God speaks today. It explains how we can understand the Bible and hear God's voice. In doing so it reveals that a proper understanding of the Bible is very important for church workers. It goes on to introduce and illustrate the four main steps we will use in understanding any book of the Bible.

Outline

- Introduction: The importance of understanding the Bible
- Romans 15:4 and hearing God's voice today
- The challenge of understanding the Bible
- The process of understanding the Bible
- Illustrating the four steps of understanding the Bible
- Conclusion

Outcomes

By the end of the unit you will be able to

1. Explain how someone can recognise God's voice today
2. Illustrate why God's speech in the past still speaks today
3. Point out the challenges we face in understanding the Bible
4. State the four steps for understanding a book of the Bible
5. Apply the four steps to a Bible verse

2.1 THE IMPORTANCE OF UNDERSTANDING THE BIBLE

In Unit 1 we learnt that in the word BUILD, the letter B stands for Biblical. We recognised the importance of keeping the Bible central in life and ministry. The letter U stands for Understanding. We discussed the challenge of using the Bible well.

That discussion was based on 2 Timothy 2:15: "Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved, a worker who does not need to be ashamed and who correctly handles the word of truth."

But why is it so important to understand the Bible? We will begin to answer that by asking a different question: How does God speak today?

Carry out these exercises in a group or groups:

- List the ways in which you and others think that God speaks to people today.

- Arrange the 'sources' in your list in order of importance by numbering them.

2.2 ROMANS 15:4 AND HEARING GOD'S VOICE TODAY

Read Romans 15:4 out loud together:

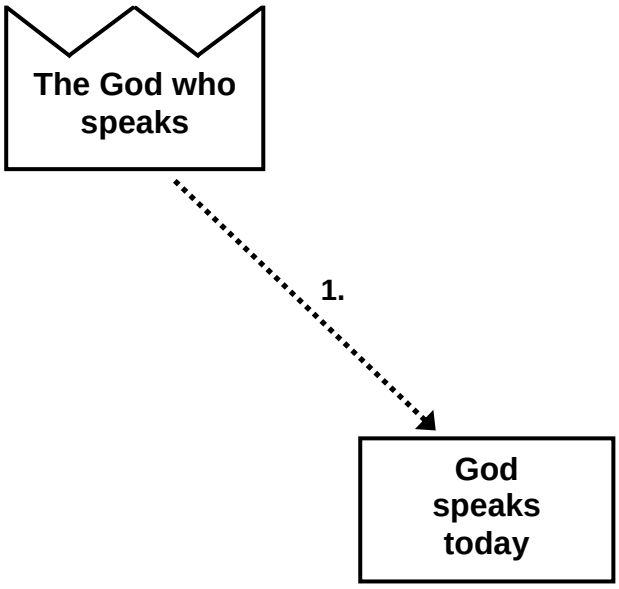
> "For everything that was written in the past was written to teach us, so that through the endurance taught in the Scriptures and the encouragement they provide we might have hope."

- What do you think this verse tells us about God and how he speaks today?

The principles Romans 15:4 contains are illustrated below. The shape at the top is a crown: a symbol for God's Kingship, which will be used elsewhere in the BUILD course.

2.2.1 The God who speaks today

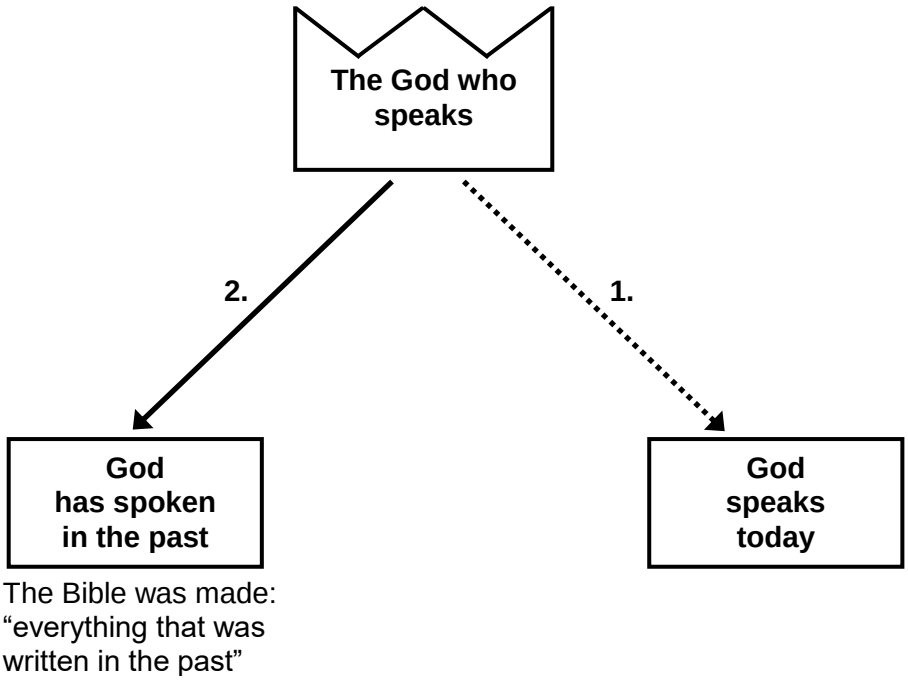
God is a speaking God (Genesis 1:3) and we have begun to discuss the claims that he continues to speak in a range of different ways today. This is indicated by the broken line (1.) in the diagram below.



But how can we recognise God's voice? How can we be confident that we have heard his word? How can we discern between the spirits and the Spirit, between the "word of truth" and "godless chatter" (2 Tim 2:15-16)?

2.2.2 God has spoken in the past

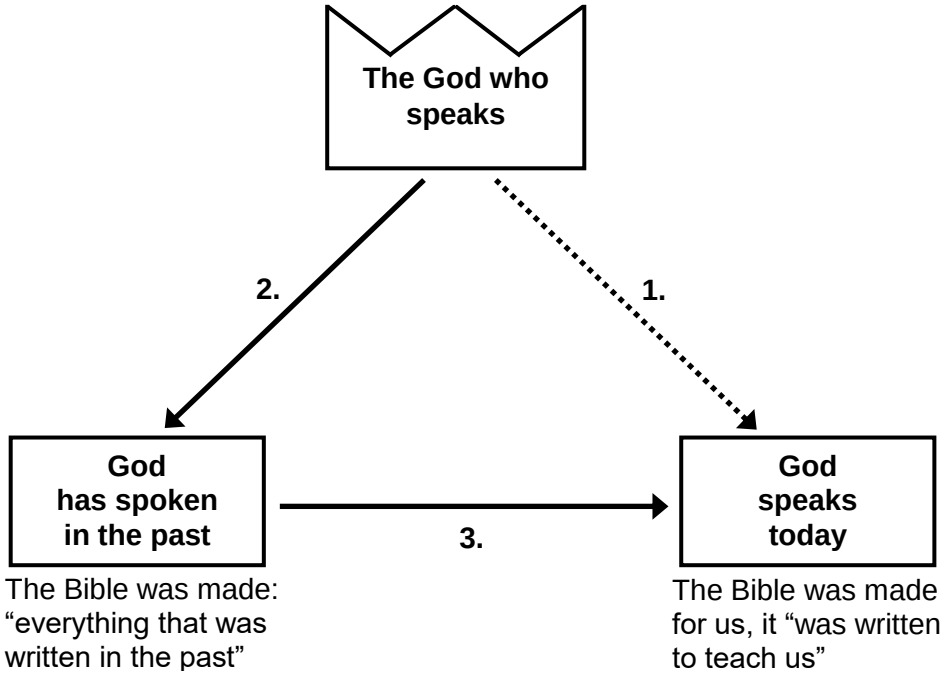
God spoke to his people in the past and those words have been captured in the Bible. When Paul says "everything that was written in the past..." in Rom 15:4 he is thinking of the Old Testament Scriptures because he has just quoted from Psalm 69:9 in verse 3. This solid truth that God has spoken in the past through the Scriptures is indicated by the solid line (2.) in the diagram.



But that leaves a gap between God's words in the past and our lives today. How does God bridge that gap and speak into our lives today?

2.2.3 God speaks today through what he has said in the past

Paul assures us that "everything that was written in the past was written to teach *us*". God speaks to us today through what he has spoken in the past. God teaches us as his written word is taught to us: as it is explained and applied with the help of God's Holy Spirit, as indicated by the solid line (3.) below.



2.2.4 The message of Romans 15:4 in summary

As Paul considers the needs of the church in Rome, he is aware that the members of the church must bear with and encourage one another (Rom 15:1-2). As he teaches them he then turns to the example of Jesus and quotes from the Hebrew Scriptures:

> "For even Christ did not please himself but, as it is written: "The insults of those who insult you have fallen on me."" (Rom 15:3 quoting Ps 69:9).

In the next verse Paul explains an important principle that flows from that: God speaks today through the Scriptures he gave in the past (Rom 15:4).

Church leaders must understand, teach and apply that word today in the light of Jesus and his gospel, in the same way that Paul explained and applied Psalm 69 to the believers in Rome. And we too must exercise endurance as we wrestle with the Scriptures, we need the encouragement they give and the hope that they bring.

When Paul used the phrase "everything that was written in the past" he was talking about the Old Testament Scriptures. The New Testament has been added to those writings to give us the complete Christian Bible. For us today, the whole Bible "was written in the past" and "was written to teach us".

This means that if we are to hear God's voice today, understanding the Bible is essential. The Bible is God's way of communicating with his people today, and it is the way in which all other words and claims are to be weighed and evaluated. The more we hear God's word and absorb it, the more naturally we will recognise God's voice and discern truth from error, just as you recognise a friend's voice on the phone after years of speaking with them face-to-face.

2.3 THE CHALLENGE OF UNDERSTANDING THE BIBLE

We have seen that in order to hear God's voice today we need to establish what he has said in the past. This is the principle of **discovering** what God has said to his people in the past before **declaring** it to his people today.

- Can you think of some of the ways in which this makes the job of understanding the Bible easier?

- Can you think of some of the ways in which that makes the job of understanding the Bible harder?

- In what ways is the situation of God's people in the past similar to our situation today?

- In what ways is the situation of God's people in the past different to our situation today?

2.4 THE PROCESS OF UNDERSTANDING THE BIBLE

We can use a step-by-step approach to understand any book of the Bible. Here are four steps to follow that we will then apply to the Pastoral Epistles.

FOUR STEPS FOR UNDERSTANDING A BIBLE BOOK

Step 1: Establish the original CONTEXT of the book

Step 2: Discover the CONTENT of the book

Step 3: Make the CONNECTIONS with our CONTEXT

Step 4: Teach the CONTENT of the book today

2.4.1 Establish the original CONTEXT of the book (Step 1)

In order to understand any spoken or written communication it is important to understand the context or situation in which it was given. What was going on then? The word 'fire' can mean different things in different settings: a source of heat ('a fire'), a command to shoot ('fire!'), or an order to get rid of someone ('fire him').

In the same way, the context is important for understanding a Bible book. We need to begin the process of understanding the Bible by establishing the situation when the Bible book was written, its 'old home'. At the same time we need to keep in mind our own context, the 'new home' in which God's voice will be heard to make the links.

The diagram below illustrates the gap between the situation in the past (on the left) and our situation today (on the right). That gap is created by differences in culture, language, history and geography, and by where the Bible book sits in the story of salvation.

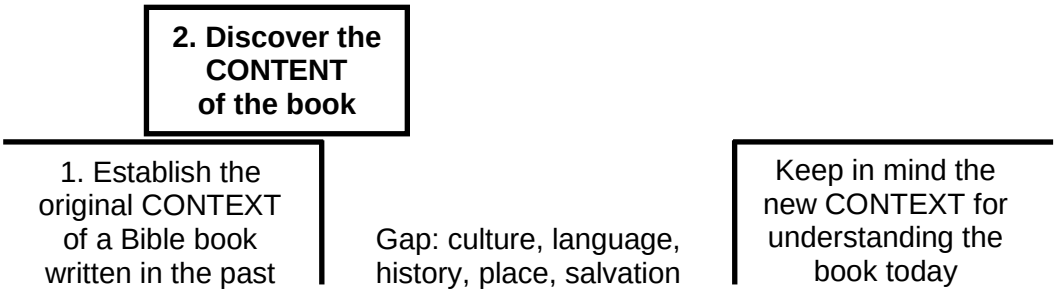
NOTE: The diagram is very simple. But imagine the gap is like a river to cross, with the world of the Bible on one side and today's world on the other side. As church leaders we need to have one foot in the world of the Bible and one foot in the world today. We need to understand both sides of the river and to build a bridge.

When you look at the diagram below you can imagine the 'content' box in Step 2 as the container of a lorry, with wheels and a driver's cabin on the front of it. Or you can draw those on. If your trainer is drawing this on a blackboard or whiteboard or flipchart they too might picture this as a lorry crossing a bridge over a river.

1. Establish the original CONTEXT of a Bible book written in the past	Gap: culture, language, history, place, salvation	Keep in mind the new CONTEXT for understanding the book today

2.4.2 Discover the CONTENT of the book (Step 2)

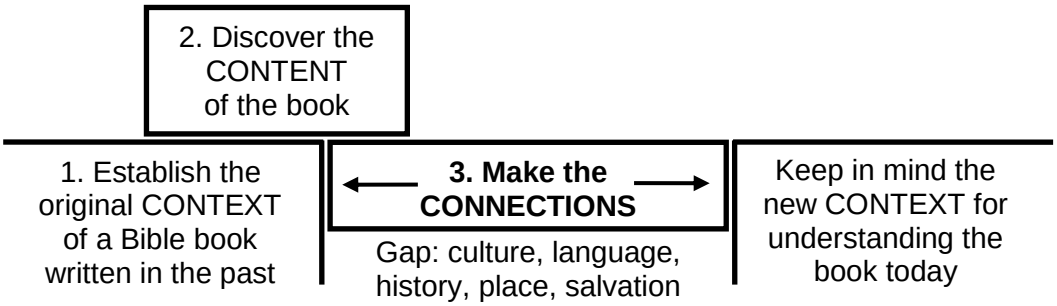
In the light of that context it is then important to discover the **CONTENT** of the book. What is the main point that the author is making to his original hearers? What main message did the book carry in its original setting, its 'old home'? What important themes did it communicate?



2.4.3 Make the CONNECTIONS with our CONTEXT (Step 3)

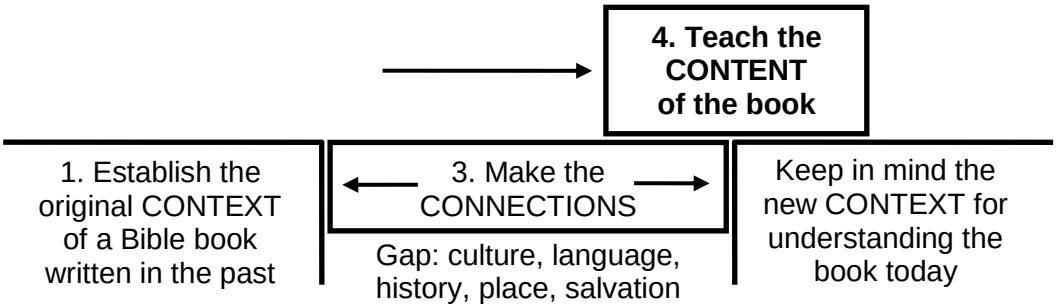
Once we have begun to discover the content of the book we need to **make the CONNECTIONS** with our situation today. This helps to fill the gap and creates a bridge to carry the content of the book over to us today, its 'new home'.

We have focussed on the difference between then and now, that create the gap. But we can also think about the ways in which our situation is similar to their situation, and how the content we are discovering speaks into our lives. For example, it might be that we are facing similar struggles and sins to our sisters and brothers in the past.



2.4.4 Teach the CONTENT of the book today (Step 4)

Finally we can teach the relevant **CONTENT** of the book today, making the connections between then and now.



2.5 ILLUSTRATING THE FOUR STEPS OF UNDERSTANDING THE BIBLE

We will apply these four steps to a book of the Bible in the next unit, where we will look at 1 Timothy together. (And we will also take a look at 2 Timothy by comparing and contrasting it with 1 Timothy.)

But we can illustrate these steps by using a single phrase in the Bible. In 2 Timothy 4:1 Paul says to Timothy, "I give you this charge".

Step1. Establishing the original CONTEXT

"I give you this charge". Think for a moment. The word 'charge' can mean a number of things, depending on the context or situation in which it is used.

- What do you think Paul meant by that word, 'charge'; which of these is the right answer?

A. An explosive device
B. A bill or invoice to be paid
C. A duty to be carried out

You will almost certainly know that C is the correct answer. Read the words that provide the context for the phrase - "I give you this charge" – which are given below to confirm your answer.

> "In the presence of God and of Christ Jesus, who will judge the living and the dead, and in view of his appearing and his kingdom, I give you this charge: preach the word…" (2 Tim 4:1-2a).

The charge Paul gives Timothy is the duty to proclaim the message of the gospel. The context of the words have helped us to understand the meaning of the words.

Step 2. Discovering the CONTENT

We have already begun to discover the content as we have looked at the context. Timothy has been given a command to obey: it is to proclaim the message of the gospel.

That command is given great weight by the fact that Christ Jesus is present with us now and will judge all people, ourselves included, and will return and establish his unshakeable kingdom in the future.

Step 3: Making the CONNECTIONS

All believers are to continue to witness to Christ Jesus today, to point to him. But those who are called to be leaders in God's church have a special responsibility to proclaim the gospel, a responsibility that continues today. The need continues and so a simple bridge has been built.

Step 4: Teaching the CONTENT

We therefore need to find ways of raising the issue of ongoing witness to Jesus with believers and teaching them about their own responsibility today. Leaders have a particular responsibility in this.

2.6 CONCLUSION

We are following in Timothy's footsteps. He was called to be "a worker who does not need to be ashamed and who correctly handles the word of truth" (2 Tim 2:15).

Correctly handling the message of the gospel means first grasping the importance of understanding the Bible. It is important because God has chosen to speak to his people today through the Scriptures he gave in the past.

Look again at Romans 15:4. Use it to pray together, that we and all God's people might be able to learn and benefit from the endurance and encouragement of the Scriptures, and have gospel hope.

> "For everything that was written in the past was written to teach us, so that through the endurance taught in the Scriptures and the encouragement they provide we might have hope." (Rom 15:4)

We will now apply this learning to 1 and 2 Timothy.